There was panic everywhere. An old lady prayed aloud, "Oh God! Have mercy on us. My only son is waiting for me in Singapore."

A gentleman consoled her, "Don't worry, Madam, it's only a warning. We may not be affected at all."

Another lady, who was sitting beside me, looked very ill. "Not rough weather! I'm already seasick. A rough sea will be the end of me!"

I could not understand why all the elders were so upset. I remembered the several sea adventures I had read about. Excitedly, I turned to the elderly gentleman sitting next to me. "Uncle, won't it be thrilling to face a storm on board a steamer? Have you ever been on a ship during a storm?"

"It can be quite unpleasant, you know," he replied rather severely. "I remember a time when the ship on which I was travelling ran off course. We were wandering on the ocean for a couple of days."

I remembered my class teacher, an English woman, telling us in class one day, "When I crossed the English Channel on my way to Singapore, there was a big storm near Gibraltar. The ship rocked to and fro. Everything in the cabins rolled up and down. Even the heavy pianos in the lounge went crashing against the walls.

This made my imagination run wild. Turning to Uncle again, I said, "Wouldn't it be fun if the storm broke when we have lunch? Then the tables, with all the food on them, would run away from us. And the chairs, with us sitting on them, would be a merry-go-round."

Everyone round the table stared at me in horror. I thought to myself, 'Oh, these adults, they've no sense of adventure. How dull they are!'

The storm didn't break, but in the evening a strong wind started blowing. The ship rocked to and fro, rocking and rolling to the music of the wind. Huge waves were dashing against it. Even though the deck was slippery, I was running around. That's when I noticed Uncle leaning over the railings. I ran up to him, thinking he too, was enjoying the experience. "Good morning, Uncle, isn't it lovely?" I asked him.

But he wasn't well at all. He was retching over the rails and looked rather blue about the mouth. I felt sorry for him. "Can I be of any help? Shall I call the doctor?' I asked him.

He couldn't reply, but only held up his hand. As another bout of retching shook him he leaned over the railings. At the same time a huge wave lashed the ship. It lurched violently and the man tumbled over the railings into the wild sea. For a second I stood

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